Research Fellow

Research Fellows play a central role in GovAI's research. They are experienced researchers who conduct independent, high-quality research to inform high-stakes decisions in government and industry, while contributing to our vibrant intellectual community.

As a Research Fellow, you will help define and address some of the most important questions in AI governance. Your work might take the form of policy memos, blog posts, academic publications, or strategic advising, with the aim of informing high-stakes AI governance decisions. You will also mentor early-career researchers, shape GovAI's research, and collaborate with our broader network.

The topics we work on include, but are not limited to: risk management, threat modeling, economics of AI, geopolitics of AI, public policy, and technical governance.

Our Research Fellows have published in leading journals, advised policymakers, helped shape important research directions, and moved into influential roles across government, industry, and academia.

We welcome candidates from a wide range of academic and professional backgrounds. Successful applicants will have a demonstrated ability to produce impactful research on important AI governance issues, and a strong commitment to positively shaping the lasting impacts of AI.

Successful candidates will join GovAI on two-year contracts, with the possibility of renewal.

Applications for the Research Fellow position are now open. The deadline for applications is 23:59 Anywhere on Earth (AoE) on Sunday, 16 August 2026.

Opportunities | July 20, 2026

About the Team

GovAI was founded to help humanity navigate the transition to a world with advanced AI. Our researchers have provided knowledge and assistance to decision makers in government, industry, and civil society. Our alumni have gone on to influential roles in government (US, UK, EU); leading AI companies, including Google DeepMind, OpenAI, and Anthropic; think-tanks such as the Center for Strategic and International Studies, Center for Security and Emerging Technology, Center for a New American Security and the Tony Blair Institute; and to leadership roles on initiatives like the International AI Safety Report. Our initial research agenda, published in 2018, helped define and shape the nascent field of AI governance. We made significant early contributions to the ongoing public discussions over the security implications of AI. More recently, we have made significant contributions to EU AI policy, with staff members vice-chairing the EU AI Act GPAI Code of Practice risk-management working group and sitting on the EU AI Office Scientific Panel & Advisory Forum.

Our researchers have published in leading journals and conferences, including Science, Nature, NeurIPS, FAccT and ICML. We have published commentary in venues such as TIME, Foreign Affairs, War on the Rocks, and Lawfare. Our work has also been covered by publications such as The New York Times, Vox, and the Financial Times.

Our staff are based across the United Kingdom, United States, and European Union.

About the Role

The Research Fellow role is designed for researchers who want to shape the future of AI governance by conducting independent, impactful research. Fellows are expected to help drive forward GovAI's core research priorities while supervising junior researchers.

Research Fellows work under the guidance of a Senior Research Fellow or member of our leadership team, but enjoy substantial autonomy in selecting projects, shaping research agendas, and deciding on publication formats. Collaboration – both within and outside of GovAI – is encouraged, and Fellows often work closely with researchers across our network. They are also expected to offer supervision and mentorship to junior researchers, such as our Summer and Winter Fellows.

Your work as a Research Fellow may involve:

- Defining and executing on a research agenda, including bringing new people onto the topic
- Informing policymakers and decision-makers on pressing governance issues
- Producing original research in the form of academic publications, policy memos, reports, or blog posts
- Organizing events that convene key stakeholders around high-priority questions
- Contributing to our research strategy and institutional priorities
- Helping assess prospective new hires for our scholar/fellow roles

We support Research Fellows by providing guidance, access to a broad network of collaborators and opportunities, and resources for research activities and dissemination.

Note: Successful applicants will have substantial research experience in a relevant area. For researchers with less experience, we offer one-year visiting **Research Scholar** positions designed to support professional development. There is a shared application for both roles, so you need only apply once.

Areas of Interest

Our researchers work on a broad range of topics related to AI governance. While much of our work concerns general-purpose AI systems, we're also interested in research on narrower AI applications and their policy implications. Our research spans several areas, including:

- **Risk Management:** How can AI companies make responsible development and deployment decisions, successfully managing risks without hindering innovation and adoption? What is the role of third parties – evaluators and auditors – in informing such decisions?
- **Threat Modeling:** What is the state of evidence regarding different hypothesized risks from AI and what further information would be most useful for reducing uncertainty? At the same time, what role can AI progress and adoption play in mitigating risks?
- **Economics of AI:** What will the economic implications of AI development and deployment be? How might it affect labour markets, competition, and growth?
- **Geopolitics of AI:** What strategies are different states using to compete in AI and how effective will they be? How do geopolitical dynamics shape AI development and governance?
- **Frontier AI regulation:** What effects will different regulatory proposals have on frontier AI? In what ways will existing regulation need to be amended or removed in light of AI developments?
- **Technical Governance:** What technical work could help address challenges in AI governance? To what extent is compute an important tool? How can evaluations keep pace with AI progress?

We are also interested in researchers pursuing other topics, including the implications of AI R&D automation, the use of AI by governments, increasing society's resilience in anticipation of advances in AI, and how society can capture AI benefits.

Qualifications and Selection Criteria

We are open to candidates with diverse academic and professional backgrounds. Past Fellows have included researchers with experience in computer science, political science, public policy, economics, philosophy, and law, as well as professionals from government, industry, and civil society.

There are no strict educational requirements for this role. However, the most promising candidates will typically have multiple years of relevant research or policy experience and a track record of producing high-quality work.

Essential Qualifications

Successful candidates will have:

- A demonstrated ability to produce excellent research, ideally within or adjacent to the domain of AI governance
- A strong interest in positively shaping the lasting impacts of AI, in line with our mission
- Established expertise in a domain relevant to AI governance
- Broad familiarity with the field of AI governance
- A compelling research proposal with a well-reasoned path to impact

What We Value

They will also likely demonstrate:

- Self-direction and a desire for impact
- Strong judgment about research prioritization
- Intellectual honesty and rigor
- Clear communication and collaboration skills
- Motivation to mentor others and contribute to a strong research culture

Additional Considerations

We especially welcome candidates with deep expertise in a particular area of relevance, such as technical governance, frontier safety design, cybersecurity, or US policy. We also encourage applications from individuals with strong applied experience, including advising policymakers or leading strategic initiatives in industry or civil society.

Duration, Location, and Salary

Duration

Contracts are full-time and last two years on a fixed-term basis, with the possibility of renewal.

Location

We typically prefer candidates to be based in London, UK or Washington, DC, but are open to candidates based elsewhere (e.g. the Bay Area).

In some cases, we have stronger location preferences:

- **Policy-focused work:** If you plan to focus heavily on government policy, we prefer you to be based in or near the relevant city (e.g. Washington DC for US federal policy).
- **Project management roles:** If you'll be managing projects or launching new initiatives, we will often prefer you work out of one of our offices.
- **Supervisor preferences:** Some supervisors prefer their supervisees to be based in the same office as them.

We are able to sponsor visas in the UK. We can only support visa sponsorship in exceptional cases in the US, and in many instances, will not be able to support a visa petition. If location constraints might affect your ability to apply, please contact recruitment@governance.ai.

Salary

Compensation is based on experience and location. Successful candidates based in London typically receive between **£84,000 and £103,500** per year, and those based in Washington, DC typically earn **$134,500–$170,000**.

We offer additional compensation for candidates in higher cost-of-living regions, such as the San Francisco Bay Area. There may be additional flexibility in compensation in cases where salary considerations would prevent a candidate from accepting an offer.

Other benefits of the role include:

- Health, dental, and vision insurance
- A £5,000 annual wellbeing budget (a salary uplift in lieu of this budget for US-based staff)
- A £5,000 (~$6,500) annual professional development budget
- A £5,000 (~$6,500) annual childcare budget
- Remote staff get a £4,500 (~$6,000) annual coworking space budget
- Flexible work hours
- Extended parental leave
- Ergonomic equipment
- A 10% employer pension contribution
- 33 days of paid vacation (including public holidays)

Please contact recruitment@governance.ai if you have questions or concerns regarding compensation or benefits that might affect your decision to apply.

How to Apply and What to Expect

Application Process

The selection process has three stages:

1. Written application
2. An abstract reasoning assessment
3. 1-2 paid remote work tests.
    1. Candidates who reach this stage will also be asked to produce a detailed research agenda outlining how they would approach their first two years at GovAI
    2. Some workstreams will require a second paid work test
4. Two interviews and reference checks

Special Circumstances

Please contact recruitment@governance.ai if you:

- Need a decision communicated by a particular date
- Require assistance with the application due to a disability
- Have questions about the application process

Addressing complex AI governance challenges requires many different skillsets and perspectives. **We welcome applicants from a wide range of backgrounds.** If our mission excites you, we encourage you to apply, even if your experience doesn't align perfectly with every qualification listed. Your unique combination of experience and motivation might be exactly what we're looking for.

Apply

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